34. Meditation — every major type, from ancient traditions to modern science

Oracle OS guide. Source texts in the library: Upanishads, Bhagavad Gita, Yoga Sutras of Patanjali, Hatha Yoga Pradipika, Dhammapada, "With Each & Every Breath" (Thanissaro), "Mindfulness in Plain English" (Gunaratana), Tao Te Ching, Marcus Aurelius' Meditations, "The Practice of the Presence of God" (Brother Lawrence), "The Imitation of Christ", WHO "Doing What Matters in Times of Stress" and US Army FM 7-22 (sleep, breathing and mind).

Getting started (applies to almost all)

- **Posture**: seated with the back upright but not rigid (chair, cushion or kneeling), hands resting, chin slightly tucked. You can also meditate lying down (for sleep) or walking.
- **Time**: 5–10 minutes daily beats an hour now and then. Build up slowly.
- **The mind will wander**: that's normal. Meditation is precisely noticing and **coming back**, without self-criticism.
- **Caution**: meditation can bring up difficult emotions and memories. With trauma, severe depression, psychosis or panic attacks: short sessions, eyes open, focus on the body and surroundings, and support from someone you trust or a professional. If distress grows, stop and do something grounding (walk, cold water on the hands, talk to someone).

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1. Ancient India — Vedic and yogic traditions (c. 1500 BCE onward)

- **Mantra / Japa**: repeat a sacred word or phrase (Om, "So Ham", "Om Namah Shivaya", a name of God) aloud, whispered or silently; traditionally 108 times on a mala (bead rosary). When the mind wanders, return to the sound.
- **So-Ham / Hamsa**: silently hear "So" on the in-breath and "Ham" on the out-breath ("I am That"). Joins mantra and breath.
- **Self-inquiry (Atma vichara)** — Upanishads; Ramana Maharshi (20th century): ask "Who am I?" and trace the source of the "I" thought without accepting verbal answers.
- **Dharana → Dhyana → Samadhi** (Yoga Sutras): fix attention on an object (flame, image, point between the brows, breath), sustain it continuously (meditation) until the split between observer and object dissolves (absorption).
- **Trataka (steady gazing)** — Hatha Yoga: gaze at a candle flame 1 m away without blinking until the eyes water, then close them and hold the inner image. Avoid with epilepsy.
- **Nada Yoga (inner sound)**: close the ears and listen to inner sounds (humming, bells, flute), following the subtlest.
- **Pranayama as meditation**: alternate-nostril breathing, Bhramari (see "Yoga").

- **Yoga Nidra (yogic sleep)**: lying down, rotate awareness through the body, notice opposite sensations (warm/cold), images and an intention (sankalpa). Rooted in ancient tantric practices (nyasa); the modern form was systematised by Swami Satyananda in the 1960s. Excellent for insomnia and exhaustion.
- **Chakra and Kundalini meditation** (tantric traditions, 8th–16th centuries): see "Chakras".
- **Bhakti (devotion)**: chanting (kirtan), visualising and offering the heart to a form of the divine.

2. Jainism

- **Samayika**: 48 minutes of equanimity — sit, renounce attachment and aversion, observe the soul as pure witness.
- **Preksha**: perception of breath, body and inner colours (modern form).

3. Buddhism (from the 5th century BCE)

- **Samatha (calm)**: concentration on one object until the mind is stable and serene.
- **Anapanasati (mindfulness of breathing)** — the Buddha; 16 steps in 4 tetrads: body (long breath, short breath, whole body, calming), feelings (rapture, ease), mind (knowing, gladdening, steadying, releasing the mind) and wisdom (impermanence, fading, cessation, letting go). Simple practice: feel the air at the nostrils or the belly; count 1 to 10 and restart if you lose count.
- **Satipatthana (4 foundations of mindfulness)**: observe body, feelings (pleasant/unpleasant/neutral), mind states and phenomena (hindrances, senses, factors of awakening).
- **Vipassana (insight)**:
  - *Noting* (Mahasi Sayadaw style, Burma): silently note "rising, falling" of the belly and label what arises: "thinking", "hearing", "pain"…
  - *Body sweeping* (U Ba Khin / S. N. Goenka): move attention from head to feet observing sensations without reacting, seeing that they change.
- **Metta (loving-kindness)** and the 4 **Brahmaviharas**: wish "May I be safe, healthy, at peace, may I live with ease", then for a loved one, a neutral person, a difficult person and all beings. Then **karuna** (compassion), **mudita** (joy in others' happiness) and **upekkha** (equanimity).
- **Recollections (anussati)**: of the qualities of the Buddha, the teaching, the community, generosity; **maranasati** (contemplation of death) to value time.
- **Walking meditation (cankama / kinhin)**: walk slowly 15–20 steps, feeling lift, move, place of each foot; turn and return.
- **Zen** (China/Japan, 6th–13th centuries):
  - *Zazen / Shikantaza* ("just sitting", Soto school): eyes half-open resting on the floor 1 m ahead, firm posture, let thoughts pass with no object.
  - *Koan* (Rinzai school): hold a paradoxical question ("What was your face before your parents were born?") until habitual thinking breaks; traditionally with a teacher.
- **Tibetan Buddhism**:

    - *Shamatha with an object* (stone, image, breath).
    - *Tonglen* (giving and taking): breathing in, imagine taking in someone's suffering as dark smoke; breathing out, send relief as light. Builds compassion without avoiding pain.
    - *Deity visualisation and mantras* (e.g. "Om Mani Padme Hum" of Avalokiteshvara) — Vajrayana practices traditionally transmitted by a teacher.
    - *Mahamudra / Dzogchen*: resting in the nature of awareness itself — requires guidance.
- **Pure Land**: reciting the name of Amitabha Buddha ("Namo Amituofo" / "Namu Amida Butsu") with faith and attention.

4. China — Taoism and internal arts

- **Zuowang ("sitting and forgetting")** — Zhuangzi: let go of perception, knowledge and self until one with the Tao.
- **Shouyi ("guarding the One")**: holding attention at the centre of body and spirit.
- **Dantian breathing**: attention three fingers below the navel, slow low breathing; basis of Qigong and internal martial arts.
- **Microcosmic orbit**: guide attention with the breath up the spine to the crown and down the front of the body to the belly.
- **Zhan Zhuang ("standing like a tree")**: standing, knees softly bent, arms as if hugging a tree, 5–20 minutes still and relaxed.
- **Tai Chi and Qigong**: slow moving meditation.

5. Greece and Rome — Stoicism and philosophers

- **Evening review** (Seneca, Pythagoras): "What did I do well? Where did I fall short? What will I do differently?"
- **Premeditation of adversity** (premeditatio malorum): calmly imagine possible losses so you can face them with composure and appreciate the present.
- **View from above** (Marcus Aurelius): imagine rising to see the city, the country, the Earth — putting problems in perspective.
- **Dichotomy of control** (Epictetus): separate what is up to you (judgements, actions) from what is not, and spend energy only on the first.

6. Christian traditions

- **Jesus Prayer / Hesychasm** (Desert Fathers, 4th century; Philokalia): repeat "Lord Jesus Christ, Son of God, have mercy on me" with the breath, bringing attention "from the head into the heart".
- **Lectio Divina** (St Benedict, 6th century): read a Bible passage slowly (lectio), chew on one phrase (meditatio), respond in prayer (oratio), rest in silence (contemplatio). The Bible in English and Portuguese is in the library.
- **Ignatian contemplation and the Examen** (St Ignatius, 16th century): imagine yourself inside a Gospel scene with all five senses; at night, review the day with gratitude.

- **Rosary**: meditative repetition of prayers while contemplating episodes of Christ's life.
- **Centering Prayer** (1970s, inspired by "The Cloud of Unknowing", 14th century): choose a simple sacred word and, whenever a thought arises, gently return to it; 20 minutes.
- **Practice of the presence of God** (Brother Lawrence, 17th century): keep an inner conversation with God during ordinary tasks.
- **Taizé chant**: short phrases sung repeatedly in a group.

7. Jewish traditions

- **Hitbodedut** (Rabbi Nachman of Breslov, 18th century): speak alone with God, quietly, in nature, in your own words, daily.
- **Contemplative recitation of the Psalms**; **Shabbat** as mindful rest; Kabbalistic meditations on divine names (traditionally with a teacher).

8. Islam and Sufism

- **Dhikr (remembrance of God)**: repeat "La ilaha illallah", "Allah", or "Subhanallah, Alhamdulillah, Allahu Akbar" (33 times each, on a tasbih), with attention in the heart.
- **Muraqaba (watchfulness)**: sit in silence aware of God's presence.
- **Tafakkur (contemplation)**: reflect on nature and creation.
- **Sema** (Mevlevi whirling, the tradition of Rumi): prayer in movement, learned in community.

9. Indigenous and nature traditions

Across many peoples: contemplative silence in nature, rhythmic drumming, chant, watching the sky and the cycles. An accessible practice: sit 20 minutes in the same outdoor spot every day, only listening and watching.

10. Modern and scientific methods (20th–21st centuries)

- **Progressive muscle relaxation** (Jacobson, 1920s): tense 5 s and release 15 s each muscle group — feet, legs, buttocks, belly, hands, arms, shoulders, face.
- **Autogenic training** (Schultz, 1932): silently repeat "my right arm is heavy… warm…", then whole body, calm heart, easy breathing.
- **Relaxation response** (Benson, 1975): repeated word + passive attitude, 10–20 minutes.
- **Transcendental Meditation** (1950s): personal mantra 20 minutes twice a day (taught by instructors).
- **MBSR — Mindfulness-Based Stress Reduction** (Kabat-Zinn, 1979) and **MBCT** (to prevent depression relapse): body scan, breathing, gentle yoga, everyday mindfulness.
- **Body scan**: lying down, move attention from the toes to the top of the head, noticing sensations without changing them, 10–40 minutes.

- **Open monitoring**: no fixed object; notice whatever arises (sounds, thoughts, sensations) and let it pass.
- **Visualisation / guided imagery**: imagine a safe place in detail (sounds, smells, temperature).
- **Gratitude**: write down 3 good things from the day and why.

11. Breathing to calm the body now

- **Box (4-4-4-4)**: in 4 s, hold 4, out 4, hold 4; 4 cycles. Used by soldiers and first responders.
- **4-7-8**: in 4, hold 7, out 8 through the mouth; 4 cycles (sleep).
- **Coherent breathing**: ~6 breaths per minute (5 s in, 5 s out) for 5–10 minutes.
- **Physiological sigh**: two short in-breaths through the nose followed by one long out-breath through the mouth; 1–3 times.
- **Long exhale**: always breathe out longer than in (e.g. 4 in, 6–8 out).

12. Short practices for emergencies and disasters

- **5-4-3-2-1 grounding** (panic, flashbacks): name 5 things you see, 4 you touch, 3 you hear, 2 you smell, 1 you taste.
- **STOP**: Stop, Take a breath, Observe (body, emotion, situation), Proceed with the most useful action.
- **Hands on the chest**: one hand on the heart and one on the belly, feel the warmth, tell yourself "this is really hard; I am doing the best I can".
- **Grief**: light a candle, say the name of the one lost, breathe with the pain without pushing it away; share with someone.
- **To sleep in a shelter**: lying body scan + 4-7-8 breathing or Yoga Nidra.
- To support others in crisis, see "WHO — Psychological first aid" and the "Mental health in a crisis" guide.